

ROBERTA SANTIAGO

Senior Product Designer · B2B SaaS · Design Systems · AI Products

Novara, Italy (CET, 50 km from Milan) · Italian residence card as the family member of an EU citizen · Full working rights in Italy today, and no employment permit or employer sponsorship is required anywhere in the EU · Open to on site, hybrid, remote and relocation anywhere in Europe, and to the United Kingdom with visa sponsorship

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Senior product designer, 9 years across fintech, carbon markets, broadcast, automation and AI products. I work where product strategy meets system structure, which in practice means information architecture, service and data modelling, permission models for products with several kinds of user, end-to-end flows, high-fidelity UI, and the design systems that keep the answer consistent once several teams build against it. The question that keeps finding me is which judgements a system is allowed to make on its own and which it has to hand back to a person. I run my own studio, so I have carried products from the first conversation to a shipped release, including the commercial and engineering trade offs in between, and I have led designers as well as engineers while doing it.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Senior Product Designer · Kolabs, product design studio

2017 to present · Curitiba, Brazil, then Novara, Italy · Founder and design lead

- Independent product design practice since 2017, operating as Kolabs from 2018. 9 years of continuous design work across fintech, carbon markets, broadcast, field operations, automation and AI products.
- Own the full arc on every engagement. Discovery and user research, information architecture, system modelling in UML, flows and use cases, data and validation rules for engineering handoff, end-to-end flows, high-fidelity UI, and release.
- Build and maintain design systems and component libraries that engineering uses as the single source of truth.
- Have led designers as well as engineers. A product designer on Figma and brand work, and UX designers I brought in and trained myself. One of them I trained from zero, and within a year and a half she was hired at mid level elsewhere and made supervisor.
- Hired and trained four designers and close to ten engineers over the years, every one of them arriving as a junior, and every one of them going on to a role above the level they came in at.
- Deliver working front end. I build with Claude, run the output through my own cleaning and testing steps, have an engineer verify the quality, and hand it back, so what leaves my hands already runs in a browser. I specify it, review it and say when it is not good enough, which on a React and TypeScript codebase with two engineers is the part that matters.
- Designed the role taxonomy and the human approval gates for Kolabs Forge, our internal pipeline that carries a briefing through a chain of AI agents to a deployable project. The engineering is my chief technology officer's. Mine is who each agent is, what it is asked, and where the three points are at which a person has to approve before anything continues.
- Run my own research. Planning, sessions and synthesis, rather than waiting for a research function.

Customer Success Manager · Ateliware

January to August 2017 · Curitiba, Brazil

- Turned structured feedback from 300+ active clients into prioritised UX improvements, and supported QA by reporting defects and validating fixes from the user side.

SELECTED PROJECTS

Client work delivered through Kolabs

Carbono Neutro · carbon credit exchange · live in Brazil

4 kinds of user share one product and one component set, a consumer, a partner store, a collaborator and a commercial representative, each with their own dashboard and statement and none of them able to see the other people's numbers. I settled the permission model before anything was styled, which is why it is one product rather than four.

Next Day · B2B2C event network · iOS

A 56-screen product map across 5 stakeholder types, delivered as 117 high-fidelity screens, with a fully documented design system covering foundations, components, roles, motion and voice, adopted by engineering as the single source of truth.

RIC TV · second screen for live television

8 kinds of audience input arrive in the same second and leave as one moderated stream going to air. Who can publish, who can only reply and who can delete is the design rather than a setting.

Luckify · white-label raffle platform

I stopped policing consistency by hand and built the Figma plugin that generates the screens instead, because tooling was cheaper than discipline. The team designs with it.

FlexScan · retail algorithmic trading · built for InvestFlex

They had statistical algorithms running inside the brokerage and little else. We made the platform into a platform. I did the front end, the UX and the layer that connects the bots, across long and short by cointegration, Kalman filters, and Markowitz portfolios opened to short selling. The work was making quantitative methods operable by a retail investor without pretending the risk is simpler than it is. InvestFlex was acquired by Órama in 2021.

Gamma Quant · quantitative trading platform · live in Brazil

The whole product, from the visual identity through to the bot system that connects to the brokerage, built on the client's own quantitative algorithms. Adaptive Kalman filtering and pair trading on index and dollar futures. It still runs today as the platform behind their training programme.

Also B.House, offline-first building inspection with computer vision on sync · Kontrol, modular automation core that turns business data into workflows · Korb, AI personal assistant · ConsultData, clinic records and analytics · Lumen, business technology platform · GeoBot, now respond.io, WhatsApp campaign automation

SIDE PROJECTS

- Veil Protocol, The Other Side. Occult investigation interactive fiction set in a hidden Tokyo, designed and built alone, front end and back end, playable in the browser. Branching scenes with consequences that persist, a world clock that runs between choices, an in game phone with characters who warm or cool depending on how you treat them, five routes and multiple endings. betstg.github.io/veil-protocol-game
- SOLPHI. A digital reading platform, designed and built solo. betstg.github.io/SOLPHI

RESEARCH

Student Researcher, Smart Corridor · GEPTA Research Group, Federal University of Paraná

2015 to 2016 · Curitiba, Brazil

An intelligent access control device for pedestrian flow, designed for accessibility through audiovisual guidance for visually and hearing impaired users. I contributed to methodology definition, analysis of sensor and automation technologies, and validation of user access during implementation. Supervised by Prof. Dr. Luiz Antônio Pereira Neves. gepta.weebly.com/smart-corridor.html

PUBLICATIONS

- Teoria do Design, Design Theory. A practitioner book on interface design. Semiotics, Gestalt, perspective, optical distortion, iconisation, diegetic interfaces, UI typography, and a 2026 chapter on accessibility covering WCAG 2.1 AA and the European Accessibility Act. Nine chapters, 143 illustrations, Portuguese and English.
- Empresas do futuro, Companies of the Future. Twelve chapters on innovation strategy, process design and digitalisation for business owners. Portuguese and English.
- Simplificando a digitalização, Simplifying Digitalisation. Five sections on why software designed around function fails to hold people, and what immersion changes. Portuguese and English.

EDUCATION

Federal University of Paraná (UFPR), Curitiba, Brazil · Product Design, 2012 to 2015 · Systems Analysis and Development, 2016 to 2020 · Universidade Positivo, Curitiba, Brazil · Systems Analysis and Development, 2024 to 2025

Coursework completed, no degree conferred.

SKILLS

Core Product strategy · Information architecture · User flows and wireframing · Interaction design · End-to-end product design · High-fidelity UI · Prototyping in Figma and in code · Design systems, component libraries and design tokens · Permission and role models for multi-role B2B SaaS · Service and system modelling in UML, flows and use cases · Data and database modelling · Field specification and validation rules for engineering handoff

Research and evidence Discovery · Qualitative and quantitative user research · Interviews, synthesis and usability testing · A/B testing and experiment design · Accessibility to WCAG 2.1 AA, WCAG 2.2 and EN 301 549 · European Accessibility Act

Collaboration and delivery Cross-functional work with product management and engineering · Stakeholder management across client, engineering and commercial · Roadmap input and prioritisation · Design review and mentoring · Agile delivery

AI and automation AI-integrated product design · Human-in-the-loop and guardrail patterns · AI-assisted prototyping with Claude, Cursor and Figma Make · Local model workflows with Ollama · Automation logic with n8n and Zapier · Prompt engineering

Platforms Android and Material Design 3 · iOS and Human Interface Guidelines · Responsive web · Accessibility to WCAG 2.1 AA and EN 301 549

Tools and delivery Figma to advanced level including plugin development · Adobe Suite · HTML, CSS, basic React and Rails · Postgres, MySQL, SQLite, MongoDB · Git, GitHub, Vercel, Cloudflare · FigJam, Miro, Jira, Notion · Storybook · Mermaid

Languages Portuguese, native · English, C1 and used every working day · Italian, A2 and improving